E-tiGo — Scheduled Rides: Decisions Report

Prepared by: Engineering Team
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Status: Implemented (PR #91; client decisions applied in PR #94 and the fees and balance-due update). Values marked **client** were set by the client (Augustus Opara) on 16 October 2026: the booking window (30 minutes to 3 days ahead), 3 upcoming bookings per passenger, no reservation fee, a late-cancellation fee of the economy base fare within 30 minutes of the ride, and a balance due for late cancellations that cannot be charged and for wallet fares the wallet cannot cover. All other values are defaults chosen by engineering to match industry practice and **have not been confirmed by the client yet**. Operations can change every one of them at any time, without a release, from **Admin › Settings › Scheduled rides** (`PUT /api/v1/admin/settings/scheduled-rides`).

Executive Summary

Passengers can now book a ride for later. The design follows the scheduled-ride products of Uber (Uber Reserve), Bolt and Lyft. The passenger books and is quoted a fixed price. Drivers can commit to the booking in advance. Shortly before pickup the ride either goes to the committed driver or is matched like any other ride.

This report lists every product decision we had to make, what competitors do, what we chose and why. Section 6 lists the decisions we need from the client. They are also tracked in the Open Questions Decision Report (SR-1 to SR-7).

Competitor terms vary by country and change over time. The figures below come from the companies' public pages and launch announcements (sources at the end); treat them as typical practice, not exact current terms in Nigeria.

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1. Booking Rules

Decision	Industry practice	E-tiGo default	Why
Earliest pickup	Uber: 30 minutes to 2 hours ahead, depending on market	**30 minutes** after booking (**client**)	Confirmed by the client. Long enough for a driver to commit and for dispatch to start on time; short enough to cover "later today" trips
Latest pickup	Lyft: 7 days. Bolt: 3 days (London launch), 72 hours (South Africa), 90 days (New Zealand). Uber: 30–90 days	**3 days** ahead (**client**)	Set by the client. Matches Bolt's London and South Africa launches; the short horizon also keeps the locked price close to current rates

Decision	Industry practice	E-tiGo default	Why
Upcoming bookings per passenger	Not published	**3** (**client**)	Set by the client. Stops one account from holding many slots (and many reserved drivers) speculatively
Gap between one passenger's bookings	Not published	**30 minutes**	Catches accidental double bookings without blocking a return trip
Booking while on a trip	Allowed by all three	**Allowed**	A scheduled booking is not an active ride, so it never blocks riding now, and riding now never blocks booking for later
Timezone	—	Pickup time must carry a UTC offset	Avoids a pickup silently shifting by an hour
Switch	—	Operations can turn new bookings off (`enabled`)	Existing bookings still go ahead

2. Price and Payment

Decision	Industry practice	E-tiGo default	Why
When the price is fixed	Lyft locks the rate at booking, including predicted Prime Time. Bolt fixes it when a driver accepts	**At booking**, an upfront fare like every E-tiGo ride	The passenger knows the price when they commit
Surge on a future pickup	Lyft predicts it	**Time-based and manual surge in effect at the pickup time** apply; **demand surge never does**	Live demand says nothing about next Tuesday. Scheduled bookings are also left out of the live demand count
Promo codes	—	Must be valid **at the pickup time**; peak/off-peak rules follow the pickup time	The discount is for the trip, so the trip time decides
Editing	Uber and Lyft allow edits until shortly before pickup	Time, pickup, destination and payment method can change **until matching starts**. The fare is quoted again	Same as booking a new ride, without losing the booking
Wallet payment	—	Balance checked at booking, **held only at dispatch**	Holding money for up to a week would be unfriendly. A reminder warns if the balance is short
Ride PIN	—	Issued **at dispatch**	PINs are valid for 6 hours, so one issued days earlier would expire

3. Dispatch and Matching

Decision	Industry practice	E-tiGo default	Why
When matching starts	Varies; aims for the driver to arrive on time	**15 minutes** before pickup	Typical pickup ETA in Lagos traffic, plus margin

Decision	Industry practice	E-tiGo default	Why
How long to keep searching	—	Until **10 minutes after** the pickup time (never less than the standard 5-minute search)	A scheduled passenger has planned around the ride; giving up early is worse than a short wait
Search pacing	—	A new search wave every **30 seconds**	Keeps trying as drivers come online without spamming drivers
A driver who declined	—	Not offered the same booking again for 5 minutes	Avoids repeated pings
Passenger reminder	Uber and Lyft remind before pickup	**60 minutes** before pickup. Warns a wallet passenger whose balance is short	Time to top up before the hold is placed
If the ride cannot start	—	Cancelled with a clear reason sent to the passenger: wallet short or frozen, account suspended, ride type withdrawn, or the window missed	Better than sending a driver to a ride that cannot be paid for
Durability	—	Bookings live in the database and a job checks them every minute	Server restarts and deploys never lose a booking

4. Drivers Reserving Bookings in Advance

Uber Reserve lets drivers see upcoming reservations and commit to them; Bolt confirms a driver ahead in some markets. We built the same.

Decision	E-tiGo default	Why
Who can reserve	Approved drivers in the **same city and vehicle class**, not blocked by a negative balance	Same eligibility as receiving a ride offer
Until when	Until matching starts (15 minutes before pickup)	After that the normal flow takes over
Reservations per driver	**5** upcoming	Prevents one driver hoarding bookings
Gap between a driver's reservations	**60 minutes**	A driver needs time to finish one trip and reach the next pickup
Protecting the reserved pickup	Drivers get **no on-demand offers in the 60 minutes** before a reserved pickup	Uber does the same so a trip in between doesn't make the driver late
At dispatch	The ride goes **straight to the reserved driver** if they are online, free and in the right vehicle; otherwise the reservation is released and normal matching runs at once	The passenger is never left waiting for a driver who isn't there
Driver reminder	60 minutes before pickup: "be online by …"	—
Driver gives it up	Allowed until dispatch; the passenger is told and the booking returns to the pool	No penalty for now (the cancellation proposal recommends tracking, not fining, driver cancellations)
Passenger changes time or pickup	The reservation is released (destination or payment changes keep it)	The driver committed to a time and place
Operations	Can **assign, move or remove** the driver on any booking before dispatch	Covers VIP, airport and corporate bookings
What the passenger sees	Driver first name, photo, rating and vehicle once reserved	As with Uber Reserve

5. Fees and Balance Due

The client decided the fees on 16 October 2026. Context: in Phase 1 the client chose no cancellation fees (OQ-05, see the Cancellation Fee Proposal); for scheduled rides a driver has reserved, the client chose a late-cancellation fee, as Uber Reserve and Bolt charge.

Fee	Decision (client)	Industry practice
Reservation fee (`reservation_fee`)	**None** (₦0)	Uber Reserve charges one (for example £3–£5 in the UK); we found none for Lyft or Bolt scheduled rides
Late-cancellation fee (`late_cancellation_fee_basis: economy_base_fare`)	The **economy base fare** of the ride's city (for example ₦600 where Economy's base fare is ₦600). It follows the city's current Economy pricing, so it changes when pricing changes	Uber charges the trip's minimum fare; Lyft a flat $10; Bolt a cancellation fee
Late window (`late_cancellation_window_minutes`)	**30 minutes** before the ride time	Uber Reserve and Bolt (UK): 1 hour; Lyft: 30 minutes

How the late-cancellation fee works (rules from the Cancellation Fee Proposal):

- **When:** only when the passenger cancels a booking **a driver has reserved**, within 30 minutes of the ride time. Free before that, and free if no driver has reserved it (as Uber does).
- **Who gets it:** the reserved driver, **in full**, with no commission. It pays for the slot they blocked.
- **Never charged** when the passenger cancels for an emergency, a safety concern, a vehicle mismatch or a driver no-show, or when operations or the system cancel.
- **Shown in advance:** the app shows the fee as `cancellation_fee_if_cancelled_now` before the passenger confirms a cancellation.
- **Edge case — no economy pricing in the city:** the fee falls back to the base fare the ride was quoted with. Operations can also switch to a flat amount (`flat`) or turn the fee off (`off`).

Balance due (client decision). Whatever cannot be collected at once is recorded as money the passenger owes:

Case	What happens
Cash or bank-transfer booking cancelled late	The fee is recorded as a balance due at once
Wallet booking cancelled late, wallet cannot cover the fee (or is frozen)	Balance due
Card booking cancelled late, card declined or no saved card	Balance due
Card charge outcome unknown (gateway timeout)	Not recorded as a balance due, so the passenger can never pay twice; finance checks it with the provider
Wallet ride whose final fare is more than the wallet holds	The wallet pays what it can; the rest is a balance due (previously only flagged for admin review, OQ-26)

How a balance due is collected (engineering defaults following Uber and Bolt, awaiting confirmation — OQ-34 and OQ-35 in the Open Questions report):

- The passenger is notified and **cannot book a new ride until it is paid** (Uber and Bolt do the same). Finance can turn this block off.
- The passenger pays **everything outstanding at once**, from the wallet or the saved card, in the app.
- Once paid, the money goes to the driver it is owed to: the late-cancellation fee in full; an unpaid fare less the usual commission. **The driver is paid when the passenger pays**, not before.
- Finance can waive a balance (with a reason); nobody is paid.

6. Decisions Needed From the Client

#	Question	Our default
SR-1	Booking window	**Decided (client):** 30 minutes to 3 days ahead
SR-2	Confirm dispatch 15 minutes before pickup, searching until 10 minutes after?	15 / 10
SR-3	Reservation fee	**Decided (client):** no charge for reservations
SR-4	Late-cancellation fee on reserved bookings	**Decided (client):** the economy base fare, within 30 minutes of the ride time
SR-5	Late cancellations that cannot be charged (cash)	**Decided (client):** recorded as a balance due; the same for wallet fares the wallet cannot cover. How it is collected (block booking until paid; driver paid when collected) is an engineering default awaiting confirmation — OQ-34, OQ-35
SR-6	Should drivers who often give up reservations lose the ability to reserve (Bolt does this)?	Not built; tracked in the audit log
SR-7	Limits per passenger and per driver	**Partly decided: 3 upcoming bookings** per passenger (client). Still to confirm: 30 min between a passenger's bookings; 5 reservations per driver, 60 min apart

7. Settings Reference

All values can be changed at runtime by operations (`GET` / `PUT /api/v1/admin/settings/scheduled-rides`). Defaults live in `config/scheduled_rides.php` (environment variables `SCHEDULED_RIDES_*`).

Setting	Default
`enabled`	true
`min_lead_minutes`	30 (client)
`max_advance_days`	3 (client)
`dispatch_lead_minutes`	15
`reminder_minutes`	60
`matching_grace_minutes`	10
`retry_wave_delay_seconds`	30
`max_upcoming_per_passenger`	3 (client)
`min_minutes_between_bookings`	30
`driver_reservations_enabled`	true
`max_reservations_per_driver`	5
`driver_reservation_gap_minutes`	60
`driver_reservation_buffer_minutes`	60
`reservation_fee`	₦0 (client)
`late_cancellation_fee_basis`	`economy_base_fare` (client)
`late_cancellation_fee_vehicle_class`	`economy`
`late_cancellation_fee`	₦0 (used only when the basis is `flat`)

Setting	Default
`late_cancellation_window_minutes`	30 (client)
Wallet setting `block_booking_with_balance_due`	true

Sources (public pages and launch coverage; terms vary by market):

- Uber Reserve: uber.com/blog/uberreserve, uber.com/en-CZ/blog/uber-reserve, uber.com/za/en/blog/schedule-rides-in-advance-with-uber-reserve, cittimagazine.co.uk
- Bolt: taxi-point.co.uk (London launch), dailynews.co.za (South Africa launch), idealog.co.nz (New Zealand launch), bolt.eu driver guide
- Lyft: autorentalnews.com
- E-tiGo: Cancellation Fee Proposal (OQ-05)